after all, what matters is exercising self control on your part.

TOR

Tor is a network of relays, run and maintained by volunteers, that works to mask your browsing data from snoopers. You access the Tor network via the Tor browser bundle or, if you know what you're doing, via the Tor network directly via your choice of browser. The advantage of Tor, when compared to encryption protocols and HTTPS, is that the Tor network not only encrypts the data that you're sending, it also does its very best to obscure the source and destination of that data.

Essentially, anyone that tries to intercept Tor network data will just see a random assortment of data just hurtling around with no apparent rhyme or reason. With no way to isolate data sets and determine the source or destination, it's almost impossible to figure out what's going on. You can download and install Tor at http://dgit.in/15vXLeg

Maintaining your anonymity

Tor's USP is anonymizing all your web traffic, but it only works if you're sensible about what you're doing online and a follow a few simple guidelines.

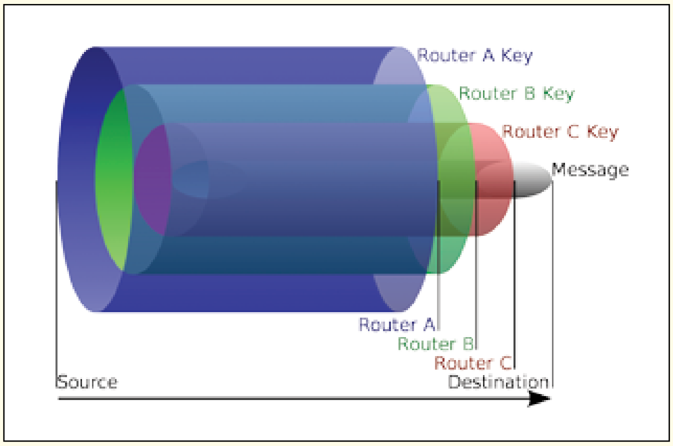
Use Tor as your default browser when you're browsing anonymously. It's been specifically configured to ensure anonymity and disables all plug-ins and other extensions that might in any way disclose identifiable information. These plug-ins include Adobe Flash and Java plug-ins and also scripts on websites.

Don't use Google. If you really want to keep your activities anonymous, avoid using Google and all its services when on the Tor network. This is because Google keeps detailed logs of any interactions with their services, no matter how seemingly insignificant. The Tor browser comes configured with a Tor "Start Page" that is designed to give you Google's search engine at your disposal, but with steps taken to anonymize all data traffic. You'll be able to search the web, but your search logs will not be traced.

Bookmarks will always be stored on your PC, so bookmark sites with caution. There's no point in meticulously maintain anonymity online, while at the same time bookmarking a log of your activities for posterity.

By default, Tor works like Chrome's Incognito mode in that it will delete your browsing history on exiting the browser, unless specified otherwise. Note that your history will be maintained for the browsing session that is active, so accidentally leaving an active session on your PC will mean that your history will be open to examination (for that session).

We'll be explaining Tor exit nodes further down this article, but we would like to point out right now that while Tor's network structure will by default keep you anonymous as far as possible, the sanctity of your data is dependent on the person that is running the Tor exit node or relay that you used. The bottom line is that while it might be almost impossible to trace your location directly, it might still be possible for people to decipher your data packets and, if you've been incautious, identify your PC via those data packets.



A brief depiction of how TOR works with your data

Files, including .doc and .pdf files, are best not opened or downloaded when you're aiming for anonymity. There is a chance, however slight, that such files might disclose personally identifiable information and Tor will warn you of such potential security risks.

If you're using Tor to achieve anonymity, logging into a website via a known id is just silly and completely defeats the purpose. If you're using the same username that you use in facebook, or login with your gmail id, you're essentially nullifying all the work that you put in to achieve anonymity. Remember to separate your anonymous self from your normal online self.

Tor is not a 100% secure. Tor is a browser like any other and security vulnerabilities will be found and exploited. Do not get complacent in your perceived anonymity because in the end, Tor is just a tool for achieving anonymity and is only as good as the people that created it.

Sending secret messages

As you must be well aware by now, all conversations on popular chatting services like Facebook Messages, Google Hangouts, WhatsApp, etc., can and will be monitored. Tor provides a simple solution for those who seek anonymity in their conversations, and it's called TorChat (http://dgit.in/1utkyhk).

TorChat keeps all data local, except for the messages that you send which are in-turn only transmitted via the Tor network and not via third-party servers. You don't even have a username in TorChat, only a public key that you must share with the person you wish to chat with. The key helps in encrypting the data that's being sent, and since no names are exchanged, you're completely anonymous unless you choose to reveal your identity. Nobody can look for and find you either because you don't exist on a database of any sort.

Staying legit

Tor is a great tool for achieving anonymity, but it's also easily exploited by criminals, making all Tor users a target for agencies like the NSA.

You could be skirting the law